

# CUPPING LIKE A PROFESSIONAL

**Professional tea tasters practice tea tasting, known as “cupping,” to evaluate the specific qualities of a tea. By training your sense of smell and taste, you will begin to identify and appreciate the complex flavors of different teas.**

## PROFESSIONAL TEA TASTERS

Considered masters of their craft, professional tea tasters and blenders “cup” hundreds of teas every day. Having developed their senses of smell and taste over years of experience, they know which characteristics to look for and which to reject. This process of evaluating tea to determine the best features and imperfections of the leaves is called “cupping.” Standard procedures are used

for every cup: 1 tsp of leaves is infused in 4½ fl oz (125ml) boiling water for 5 minutes, no matter what the type of tea. While non-professionals may find it unpleasantly bitter, this helps the tasters to select leaves that will best match the profile of their tea blend and determine a new “formula” of blends for each harvest. Their goal is to achieve consistency in a blend from an inconsistent tea harvest.

## TASTING SET

A professional tasting set consists of a tasting bowl and a small lidded cup with a handle and groove on the rim to strain out the leaves. Dry leaves are placed in the cup, and boiling water is poured over them. The lid is placed on the cup, and the tea is allowed to steep for 5 minutes. Then the cup, with the lid still on, is tipped sideways into the tasting bowl to let the tea flow into it. The used leaves are removed from the cup and placed on the inverted lid.

ALL FIVE SENSES  
ARE INVOLVED  
THROUGHOUT  
EVERY STAGE  
OF TASTING

